



DESTINATION FILE

Magnetic Island & Townsville

Yunbenun — a protected island wrapped in reef, home to Northern Australia's largest wild koala colony.

COUNTRY

Wulgurukaba Country, QLD

ACCESS

Fly to Townsville (TSV)

PAX RANKING

#6 of all destinations

STATUS

● Open · 78% protected park

01 Destination overview

LOCATION & SIZE

Magnetic Island (Yunbenun) lies 8km off Townsville in north Queensland — a short ferry ride within the Great Barrier Reef World Heritage Area. The island covers 5,184 ha, of which 78% is protected national and conservation park. Townsville is the mainland hub and a major marine-science centre.

CHARACTER

A relaxed, nature-rich island known for Northern Australia's largest wild koala colony, 23 bays and beaches, and 26km of walking trails. Much quieter and more affordable than the southern reef hubs, with a strong local conservation community.

ACCESS

Fly to Townsville Airport (TSV), then a short SeaLink ferry (about 20–25 min) from Townsville to Nelly Bay on Magnetic Island. Ferries run frequently throughout the day and are wheelchair accessible.

BEST SEASON

April–November (dry season) — warm, low humidity, ideal for walking and wildlife. December–March — hot, humid, wet season, stinger season in the water. Koalas are visible year-round along the Forts Walk.

GOVERNING BODIES

- Queensland Parks & Wildlife Service
- Wulgurukaba Traditional Owners
- Townsville City Council
- Great Barrier Reef Marine Park Authority

LEGAL FRAMEWORKS

- Nature Conservation Act 1992 (Qld)
- Great Barrier Reef Marine Park Act 1975
- Magnetic Island NP Management Statement 2023
- Queensland Heritage Act 1992

02 Wulgurukaba Traditional Owners & Yunbenun

TRADITIONAL OWNERS

The Wulgurukaba people — the 'canoe people' — are the Traditional Custodians of Magnetic Island, known to them as Yunbenun. They have an enduring connection to the island and nearby mainland stretching back thousands of years, evidenced by shell middens, stone tools and art sites.

CULTURAL SIGNIFICANCE

Yunbenun means 'spirit of the cassowary' in the Wulgurukaba language. The Wulgurukaba work with Queensland Parks & Wildlife to co-manage the island. In 2024 the Queensland Government proposed renaming the national park Yunbenun National Park in recognition of Wulgurukaba custodianship.

PRIORITY RECOMMENDATION

Acknowledge Wulgurukaba connection to Yunbenun in client communications. Use the traditional name alongside Magnetic Island, and choose experiences that interpret the island's deep Aboriginal history, not only its WWII and natural heritage.

03 Sustainability & current status

PROTECTED ISLAND

78% of Magnetic Island is protected national and conservation park, and its waters fall within the Great Barrier Reef Marine Park. This makes responsible visitation relatively straightforward, but the koala colony and fringing reefs require care.

COMMUNITY CONSERVATION

Magnetic Island has an unusually active local conservation community for its size (around 2,400 residents), supported by Townsville's status as a marine-science hub. Groups work on koala monitoring, reef health and marine debris.

POSITIVE PROGRAMS

- Magnetic Island koala monitoring
- Great Barrier Reef Foundation community projects
- Reef HQ Aquarium (Townsville)
- Marine debris removal
- Citizen science

BEFORE YOU SELL

Emphasise Magnetic Island's exceptional protected-area status and its wild koala colony — a genuine drawcard. Brief clients on koala-viewing etiquette (observe quietly, never disturb) and the island's car-light character.

04 Biodiversity & environment

WHY IT MATTERS

Magnetic Island is one of the most ecologically diverse islands of the Great Barrier Reef — combining woodland, granite headlands, fringing reef, seagrass and mangrove habitats in a small, accessible area.

KEY WILDLIFE

- Wild koalas (largest colony in N. Australia)
- Allied rock-wallabies
- Green turtles
- Dugongs
- Bush stone-curlews
- Possums
- Fringing-reef fish & coral

SPECIES TO KNOW

Koala	Protected — Northern Australia's largest wild colony. Best seen on the Forts Walk. Observe quietly; never disturb.
Allied Rock-wallaby	Protected — lives among the granite boulders. Do not feed; feeding harms their health and behaviour.
Green Sea Turtle	Endangered — rests on fringing reefs. Keep distance when snorkelling.
Dugong	Vulnerable — grazes the seagrass meadows. A key species for the island's waters.

WILDLIFE ETIQUETTE

Do not feed any wildlife, including rock-wallabies (despite popular feeding spots). Observe koalas quietly from the track and never disturb them. The fringing reefs are sensitive — use reef-safe sunscreen and don't touch coral.

05 Getting there sustainably

BY AIR & FERRY

Fly to Townsville (TSV), then the SeaLink ferry to Magnetic Island (20–25 min). The ferry is the only access and is itself a low-impact, scenic crossing within the Marine Park.

ON THE ISLAND

Magnetic Island is best explored without a private car — local buses connect the bays, and walking trails link key sites. Some visitors hire e-bikes or the iconic open-top 'Barbie cars', though buses are the lowest-impact option.

LOWER-CARBON APPEAL

The compact island, frequent ferries and bus network make a genuinely car-free visit easy — a strong sustainability point for clients, and more affordable than the southern reef hubs.

SUSTAINABLE FRAMING

Magnetic Island is one of the easiest reef destinations to visit car-free. Promote the ferry-plus-bus combination and walking trails as both the lowest-impact and most authentic way to experience Yunbenun.

06 Accessibility

OVERALL

Moderate — the ferry and main bays are accessible, but the island's signature wildlife walks involve uneven terrain.

FERRY

SeaLink ferries are designed to accommodate wheelchair users — confirm requirements when booking. Nelly Bay terminal is accessible.

AROUND THE ISLAND

The local bus service connects the main bays and is the most accessible way to get around. Horseshoe Bay and Nelly Bay have accessible foreshore areas; some beaches have better access than others.

FORTS WALK & KOALAS

The Forts Walk — the best koala-viewing trail — is an unsealed uphill track and is not wheelchair accessible. Bounce Magnetic Island's koala and wildlife park offers a more accessible alternative for close wildlife encounters.

PLAN AHEAD

For clients with mobility needs, the koala and wildlife park is a more accessible alternative to the Forts Walk. Confirm ferry and accommodation accessibility in advance.

07

Eco-certified operators

CERTIFIED OPERATORS IN THIS REGION

- Aquascene Magnetic Island — Advanced Ecotourism
- BIG4 Eco Resort Townsville — Advanced Ecotourism
- Billabong Sanctuary — Advanced Ecotourism
- Orpheus Island Lodge — Advanced Ecotourism · Climate Action
- Townsville City Council – Eco Catchment Tours — Advanced Ecotourism
- Adrenalin Snorkel and Dive — Ecotourism
- Big Mama Sailing — Ecotourism
- Magnetic Glamping — Ecotourism

+ 7 more certified operators in this region — see the full reference below.

FULL CERTIFIED-OPERATOR REFERENCE

- ↓ OJ certified-operator reference (Excel) — curated by destination, with our suppliers flagged.
- ↓ Full Ecotourism Australia register (Excel) — the complete national source file, updated quarterly.

SOURCING & CURRENCY

Showing Ecotourism Australia certified operators in this region. Verified against the Ecotourism Australia register, April 2026. Certification status changes over time — confirm before booking at ecotourism.org.au. If you download either Excel file, don't keep working from a saved copy — return to the Hub and download the latest version each time, as both the OJ reference and the full Ecotourism Australia register are updated regularly.

Sources — Queensland Parks & Wildlife Service · Townsville North Queensland · Great Barrier Reef Foundation · GBRMPA · Magnetic Island NP Management Statement 2023. Reviewed at least every 12 months.